

BEYOND THE MIRROR

Volume 1



BEGINNER FRIENDLY

Science-Backed Fitness
Tips

15-MINUTE FITNESS BUFFET

Workouts for even the
busiest schedule.

**DISCOVER WHY
REAL FITNESS IS
ABOUT MORE
THAN JUST
LOOKING GOOD.**

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01 FITNESS FOR US

"Fitness isn't about six-packs, it's about living better, one habit at a time."

"Fitness" is one of those words that scares people before they even begin. Many imagine expensive gyms, strict diets, protein shakes, and people lifting weights heavier than a motorcycle.

For many Pakistanis, fitness feels like something reserved for athletes, influencers, or celebrities rather than ordinary people. But the truth is much simpler: fitness is about improving your quality of life through movement, balanced eating, and healthy habits.

This chapter is designed for people who think they are "too busy," "too old," "too lazy," or "too out of shape" to begin. Through relatable stories, humor, myth-busting, and interactive activities, this chapter aims to prove that fitness doesn't require perfection it requires consistency.

Whether you're a university student surviving on chai, a working professional stuck behind a desk, or someone trying to escape the irresistible smell of fresh biryani at family gatherings, there's something here for you.

WHY FITNESS FEELS DIFFICULT IN PAKISTAN

Let's be honest. Living a healthy lifestyle in Pakistan isn't always easy. Many people leave home early for work or university and return late.

Traffic is exhausting.

Public parks aren't always nearby. Safe walking spaces can be limited. Summer temperatures regularly climb above 40°C. Then there are weddings. Birthdays. Family dinners. Eid. Ramadan feasts.

Office parties.

Someone is always celebrating something. Food is one of the biggest ways we show love in our culture. Saying "no" to another serving can sometimes feel more difficult than lifting weights.

Reality Check

Being healthy does not mean rejecting your culture.

It means learning how to enjoy it without letting it control your health.

Open Instagram. Within seconds you'll probably see someone with perfect abs. Perfect lighting. Perfect muscles. Perfect life. Except... It usually isn't perfect. Many fitness influencers spend years training. Some work out as a full-time job. Professional photographers, lighting, editing, camera angles and even dehydration before photos all create unrealistic expectations.

Comparing yourself to those images is like comparing your university presentation to a Hollywood movie. Fitness should inspire you—not make you feel bad about yourself.

"Your body isn't asking you to become perfect. It's asking you to take care of it a little more than you did yesterday."



MYTHS THAT MUST DIE

INTRODUCTION

Every culture has its own traditions, beliefs, and advice that gets passed down from one generation to another. In Pakistan, fitness advice is often shared just as freely as family recipes. One person says drinking hot water melts fat, another insists eating after 8 p.m. causes weight gain, while someone else believes lifting weights is only meant for men. Because these ideas are repeated so often, they begin to sound like facts.

Unfortunately, many of these beliefs have little or no scientific evidence behind them. Some are harmless, while others stop people from adopting healthier lifestyles. A beginner who believes they need expensive supplements to exercise may never start. A woman who thinks strength training will make her "look like a man" may miss out on one of the healthiest forms of exercise.

This article explores some of the most common fitness myths found in Pakistani households and explains the truth behind them. The aim is not to criticize traditions but to encourage readers to question information before accepting it. Understanding the facts allows us to make better choices for our bodies while still respecting our culture.



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*The biggest
obstacle to fitness
isn't lack of
equipment it's
believing the wrong
information.*

MYTH #1: ROTI MAKES YOU FAT



This is probably the most common statement heard in desi households.

Many people completely remove roti from their meals because they believe it is the main reason behind weight gain.

The reality is much simpler.

No single food causes obesity on its own.

Weight gain occurs when we consistently consume more calories than our body uses.

Whole wheat roti contains carbohydrates, dietary fibre, vitamins, and minerals that provide the body with energy. Removing it completely often leaves people feeling hungry, which may lead to overeating later in the day.

Instead of fearing roti, a healthier strategy is to control portion sizes and combine it with vegetables, lentils, or lean protein.

The problem is rarely the roti itself, it is eating four rotis with very little movement throughout the day.

MYTH #2: GIRLS SHOULDN'T LIFT WEIGHTS.

This myth has existed for decades and continues to discourage many women from strength training.

Some people believe lifting weights automatically makes women bulky or masculine.

Scientifically, this is incorrect.

Women naturally produce much lower levels of testosterone than men, making it extremely difficult to build large muscles without years of dedicated training and specialised nutrition.

In reality, resistance training helps women increase bone density, improve posture, strengthen joints, reduce body fat, and support hormonal health.



MYTH #3: IF YOU'RE SWEATING, YOU'RE BURNING FAT

Many people judge a workout by how much they sweat.

The more sweat, the better the workout or so they think.

Sweating is actually the body's cooling system.

It helps regulate body temperature when you exercise or when the weather is hot.

Someone can lose a litre of sweat during a workout and regain that weight immediately after drinking water.

Fat loss happens when your body consistently uses more energy than it consumes over time not because your shirt became wet.

MYTH #4: YOU HAVE TO JOIN A GYM TO BECOME FIT.

Social media often creates the impression that fitness only happens inside expensive gyms.

While gyms offer equipment and professional guidance, they are not the only option.

Walking, jogging, bodyweight exercises, skipping rope, yoga, cycling, and even climbing stairs all contribute to better health.

Many people have transformed their lives using nothing more than a small room and consistent effort.

The best workout is the one you can continue doing.

MYTH #5: HEALTHY FOOD IS ALWAYS EXPENSIVE

Another misconception is that healthy eating requires imported fruits, protein bars, and costly supplements.

Fortunately, many affordable Pakistani foods are naturally nutritious.

Eggs, daal, chickpeas, seasonal vegetables, yogurt, bananas, oats, peanuts, and whole wheat flour are excellent sources of nutrients without putting pressure on your budget.

WHY THESE MYTHS CONTINUE TO EXIST

Fitness myths survive because they are usually passed down by people we trust parents, relatives, neighbours, or friends. Their advice often comes from personal experience rather than scientific research.

Social media has made the situation even more confusing. Every week, a new influencer promotes a miracle diet, a magical detox drink, or a "secret" weight-loss hack. While some advice is helpful, much of it is exaggerated to gain views and followers.

Learning to verify information through reliable health organizations and qualified professionals is one of the most important fitness skills anyone can develop.

MYTH VS REALITY

 Myth	 Reality
Carbs make you fat.	Too many calories not carbs alone cause weight gain
Women shouldn't lift weights.	Strength training benefits women of all ages
Sweating burns fat	Sweating regulates body temperature
Healthy food is expensive	Many local foods are healthy and affordable
Gym membership is necessary	Consistency matters more than location



NOTES TO TAKE

One of the best things a person can do for their health is to become curious. Instead of accepting every piece of advice, ask a simple question: "Is there evidence to support this?"

Our culture has many wonderful traditions, including sharing meals, spending time with family, and celebrating together. Those traditions do not need to disappear for us to become healthier. What needs to change is the misinformation that often surrounds them.

Fitness should be based on knowledge, not rumours. Once we replace myths with facts, making healthy choices becomes much easier.

FITNESS VOCABULARY

CALORIES

The amount of energy found in food. Your body uses calories for everything from breathing and walking to exercising and thinking.

METABOLISM

The collection of processes your body uses to convert food into energy. Contrary to popular belief, there is no magical way to "boost" your metabolism overnight.

BMI

A simple measurement comparing weight to height. While BMI can provide a general health indicator, it doesn't measure body fat or muscle mass and should not be used alone to judge someone's health.

CONSISTENCY

Repeating healthy habits over a long period of time. Consistency is often the biggest predictor of long-term success.

02

MOVE LIKE YOU MEAN IT

INTRODUCTION

Imagine buying a brand-new car and never taking it out of the garage. It might look shiny on the outside, but over time, its engine would begin to suffer because it was never used. In many ways, our bodies work the same way. They are built to move, stretch, lift, climb, run, and adapt. Yet modern lifestyles have quietly replaced movement with sitting. We attend online classes, work behind computer screens, spend hours scrolling on our phones, and often end the day feeling tired—even though we barely moved.

Movement is one of the most powerful medicines available to us, and unlike many treatments, it is free. It improves heart health, strengthens muscles and bones, boosts mood, reduces stress, enhances sleep, and even improves concentration. The good news is that movement doesn't have to happen inside a gym. Whether it's climbing stairs, carrying groceries, playing cricket, or walking after dinner, every step contributes to a healthier body.



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**Your body was
designed to move.
The question is are
you letting it?**



STAIRS, SWEATS & STREET SMARTS

Why everyday movement might be the most underrated workout in Pakistan.

It is 8:30 in the morning. The lift is crowded, so you wait. Five minutes pass. Someone suggests taking the stairs. Almost everyone laughs. "Do I have to climb 4 Floors?"

The lift finally arrives, everyone squeezes inside, and thirty seconds later they reach their office.

Now imagine this happening every single day.

Those four flights of stairs could have been a small workout, but convenience won. This scene repeats itself across Pakistan thousands of times every day. Whether it's waiting for elevators, driving to a shop that's only a few streets away, or sitting for hours at a desk, we have gradually removed movement from our daily lives.

Ironically, many people complain that they don't have time to exercise, yet several opportunities to move are hidden within their daily routine.

Fitness does not always begin inside a gym. More often than not, it begins with ordinary movement.

THE GYM ISN'T THE ONLY ANSWER

One reason many people never begin their fitness journey is because they believe exercise must happen in a gym.

While gyms provide equipment, professional guidance, and a motivating environment, they are not the only path to better health. Some of the healthiest people in the world regularly participate in simple activities such as walking, cycling, hiking, swimming, or recreational sports.

In Pakistan, there are countless ways to stay active without spending thousands of rupees on a membership.



SMALL MOVEMENTS CREATE BIG RESULTS

Many beginners underestimate how powerful small habits can become over time.

Imagine someone who walks for just twenty minutes every day.

At first, twenty minutes may not seem significant.

But after one week, they have walked for more than two hours.

After one month, nearly ten hours.

After one year, well over one hundred hours of physical activity.

That is the power of consistency.

Our bodies respond to repeated effort, not occasional bursts of motivation.



DON'T WAIT UNTIL YOU FEEL MOTIVATED

One of the biggest misconceptions about exercise is that motivation should come first.

In reality, motivation often follows action.

Think about brushing your teeth.

Most people don't wake up feeling excited to brush their teeth.

They simply do it because it has become part of their routine.

Exercise works in exactly the same way.

The more automatic it becomes, the less motivation you need.

Successful people don't necessarily have more willpower than everyone else. They simply build habits that make healthy decisions easier.

Our surroundings influence our choices more than we realize.

If your walking shoes are buried inside a cupboard, you'll probably skip your evening walk.

If your water bottle is always empty, you'll drink less water.

If your phone charger is beside your bed, you'll likely spend another hour scrolling social media before sleeping.

Small environmental changes can produce surprisingly large results.

Place your shoes near the door. Keep a water bottle on your study desk.

Stand up and stretch every hour during study sessions.

Walk while talking on the phone.

Park your bike a little farther from your destination.

These tiny adjustments require almost no extra effort but encourage more movement throughout the day.

"You don't have to exercise like an athlete. Just move more than you did yesterday. Your body notices every step, even when you don't."



NOTES TO TAKE

There is an old saying that the best exercise is the one you actually do. Fitness doesn't begin with buying expensive equipment or waiting for Monday morning. It begins with making movement a normal part of your life again.

Whether it's climbing stairs instead of taking the lift, walking to the market instead of driving, or playing cricket with friends on a Sunday evening, these moments all count. They may seem small on their own, but together they build a healthier heart, stronger muscles, better mental health, and more energy for everyday life.

Your body was built to move. The more you move it, the more it rewards you.

MOVE MORE CHALLENGE

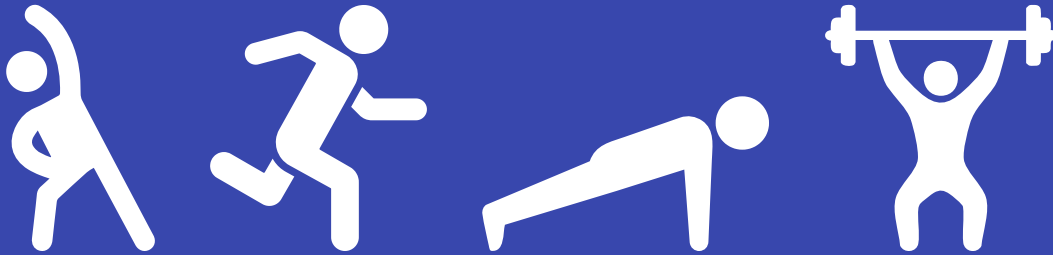
This week, try adding 2,000 extra steps to your daily routine without setting aside a dedicated workout time.

Can you do it just by changing your everyday habits?

You might be surprised by how easy and effective it is.

THE 15-MINUTE FITNESS BUFFET

No time? No problem. Choose a workout that fits your day.



Let's be honest.

One of the biggest excuses people give for not exercising is, "I don't have enough time."

University assignments pile up. Office deadlines stretch into the evening. Family responsibilities demand attention. Before you know it, the day is over and your workout has once again been postponed until tomorrow.

But what if getting healthier didn't require an hour-long gym session?

What if fifteen minutes were enough to make a meaningful difference?

Research consistently shows that even short bouts of physical activity can improve cardiovascular health, increase energy levels, boost mood, and support long-term fitness when performed consistently. While longer workouts certainly have their place, shorter sessions are often more realistic—and realistic routines are the ones people actually stick to.

Think of this section as a buffet.

Just like a buffet allows you to choose the food you want, this fitness buffet lets you choose the workout that matches your mood, schedule, and available space. There is no pressure to complete everything. Simply pick one option and get moving.



MENU 1

THE "RUNNING LATE FOR CLASS" WORKOUT

Time Required: 10–15 minutes

Perfect for students who only have a small break between lectures.

Complete three rounds of:

- 15 Bodyweight Squats
- 10 Incline Push-ups (using a desk or wall)
- 20 Jumping Jacks
- 30-second Plank

Finish with a two-minute walk.

MENU 2

OFFICE BREAK RESET

If you spend most of your day sitting behind a computer, this routine helps reduce stiffness and improve posture.

Repeat twice:

- Chair Squats × 15
- Standing Calf Raises × 20
- Shoulder Rolls × 15
- Neck Stretches × 30 seconds
- Standing March × 1 minute

You'll return to work feeling more refreshed than after another cup of tea.



MENU 3

HOME HERO CIRCUIT

No gym?

No equipment?

No problem.

Three rounds:

- Squats × 15
- Lunges × 10 each leg
- Push-ups × 8–12
- Glute Bridges × 15
- Mountain Climbers × 20

This simple routine trains nearly every major muscle group in the body.



MENU 4

THE STRESS RELIEF SESSION

Some days, your mind is more tired than your body.

Instead of an intense workout, slow things down.

Spend fifteen minutes doing:

- Deep breathing
- Gentle stretching
- Cat-Cow Stretch
- Child's Pose
- Hip Openers
- Five minutes of mindful walking

Exercise isn't always about burning calories.

Sometimes it's about reducing stress.



FITNESS BUFFET PLANNER

Draw a ✓ beside the workouts you plan to try this week.

Workout	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
Running Late for Class	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Office Break Reset	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Home Hero Circuit	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Stress Relief Session	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐





03 BEYOND THE MIRROR

The healthiest transformation isn't always the one you can see.

A fit body may catch someone's attention. A healthy life keeps it

There is a question that almost every fitness professional has been asked at some point.

"How long will it take before I see results?"

It's a fair question. We live in a world where progress is measured by numbers marks on an exam, followers on social media, likes on a post, or kilograms on a weighing scale. Naturally, when people begin exercising, they expect immediate changes. But the truth is that the first results of fitness are rarely visible in the mirror.

REDEFINING SUCCESS

Many people begin their fitness journey with one goal: to lose weight.

There is nothing wrong with wanting to improve your appearance. Looking good often boosts confidence, and feeling comfortable in your own skin is a positive thing. However, when appearance becomes the only measure of success, people often become discouraged.

Imagine two individuals.

The first person loses five kilograms in a month by following an extreme crash diet. They eat very little, avoid social gatherings, and spend hours doing cardio every day. A few weeks later, they return to their old habits and regain all the weight they lost.

The second person loses only one kilogram in the same period. However, they now sleep seven hours every night, drink more water, walk daily, cook healthier meals at home, and feel less stressed than before.

Which person has made the greater transformation?

The answer becomes obvious when we stop looking only at the weighing scale.

True fitness is measured by habits, not shortcuts.



A LETTER TO THE READER

If you've read this magazine from beginning to end, I hope one message has stayed with you. You don't need expensive supplements. You don't need perfect genetics. You don't need a luxury gym membership. You don't need to look like the people you see on Instagram.

What you need is the willingness to begin.
Maybe your first workout lasts only ten minutes.
Maybe your first walk is slower than everyone else's.
Maybe you struggle with consistency at first.
That's okay.

Every expert was once a beginner.
Every strong person once found exercise difficult.
Every healthy lifestyle begins with a single decision.
Perhaps that decision starts today.

FIVE PROMISES TO YOURSELF

Before you close this magazine, take a moment to read these promises. If you agree with them, sign your name below.

I promise to:

- ✓ Respect my body instead of criticizing it.
- ✓ Choose progress over perfection.
- ✓ Stay active, even on busy days.
- ✓ Enjoy food without guilt and eat with balance.
- ✓ Remember that health is a lifelong journey.





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When I first began planning this magazine, I thought fitness was mainly about workouts and meal plans. The more I researched and wrote, the more I realized that fitness is really about something much bigger.

It is about discipline when motivation disappears.

It is about choosing stairs instead of the lift.

It is about drinking water instead of another sugary drink.

It is about sleeping on time before an exam.

It is about enjoying traditional Pakistani food while making mindful choices.

Most importantly, it is about understanding that our bodies are not machines to be pushed until they break. They are lifelong companions that deserve care, patience, and respect.

If this magazine encourages even one reader to take a short walk, question a fitness myth, or replace an unhealthy habit with a healthier one, then it has achieved its purpose.

Thank you for reading.

Now close the magazine...

...and go for a walk.



READER'S CORNER

What healthy habit will you start this week?

Who will you invite to join you?

Where do you see yourself one year from today?

Thank You

"The journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step." — Adapted from the ancient saying by Lao Tzu